



Prof. S. Sadagopan receiving NDTV Digital Pioneer Award

engineering degree,” Prof. Sadagopan informs. However, destiny led him to Engineers India, a Delhi-based consulting firm. A talent search culminated in his recruitment, offering a novel perspective on his potential. He remembers, “They had a very unusual policy as they invited only the top two rank holders of twenty premiere Universities for an interview. So as a young person of about 20 years, I found that suddenly a company took the trouble of discovering me, even giving me a first-class train ticket to go to Delhi, and finally appointed me in a job for which I never applied. And of course, the job was also paying well, a four-figure salary of 1,040 rupees. It was a good salary in 1973. So, I joined the company as a computer engineer in the System Engineering and Computer Services Department.” As a part of that team, Prof. Sadagopan was actively involved in the computerisation of materials management for IPCL!

That job gave Prof. Sadagopan exposure to the advanced applications of computer engineering. He got an opportunity to take special computer training from a team of German experts and some interesting projects like planning the road network and the bus network for Hyderabad and Delhi, and planning for the slurry pipeline of Kudremukh Iron Ore.

Prof. Sadagopan narrates, “I was having fun at my job; however, I wanted more fun and more opportunities to learn. Thus, I started looking for higher studies. Those days, there was no email facility, but I remembered Professor Ravindran who came from Purdue University to teach in IIT Madras. He had also given lectures in my engineering college at Guindy. So, I contacted

him and he guided me to my higher studies. I cleared TOEFL and GRE and landed myself at Purdue University.” Purdue University is one of the largest engineering institutions in the United States. “The Purdue University President used to use a very nice marketing statement - The first man on the moon happens to be a Purdue alumnus; as of now, the last man on the moon also happens to be a Purdue alumnus!” says Prof. Sadagopan remembering his alma mater.

The Purdue University days were quite memorable for Prof. Sadagopan. That was a time when computer science was getting mainstream and the computer centre at Purdue was managed very well. In Prof. Sadagopan’s words, “Purdue was quite ahead of the computer revolution to solve diverse problems of humanity.” He enjoyed dabbling in large computing, large computational problem-solving, and decision support. He also got involved in an optimisation library that was used by several departments—agriculture, engineering, science, and business—

to use resources optimally. “We used to work on computer programs that were open, much before the word open source was invented. It was a set of Fortran programs for linear and integer optimisation used by the whole university.” Prof. Sadagopan explains. Later he applied that experience to share scientific and engineering program libraries at IIT Kanpur.

While discussing the influence of faculty members at Purdue University, Prof. Sadagopan mentions, “Professor Ravindran at Purdue University influenced me a lot. His way of assessing students was different from the traditional methods. He used to say that students do not haggle for more marks if they know what they deserve and why they deserve it. His explanation helped me to develop the habit of giving copious notes for all the quizzes, homework, and examinations that I corrected as a teaching assistant. I always find that students take exams seriously not only for obtaining marks but also for learning perspective; it is for the teachers to provide that learning environment”

Purdue University is located near Chicago, the place where Swami Vivekananda represented India at the Parliament of the World’s Religions in 1893. “Because of my connection with Ramakrishna Math, I was very curious to know about Swami Vivekananda’s coverage and journey in Chicago, as I was inspired by the way Swami Vivekananda presented India there. I found something amazing about it

Awards and Accolades

- Fulbright Fellowship (1995)
- Champion of Humanity, Award of Hindustan Chamber of Commerce (2009)
- Rotary Honor of Vocational Excellence by Rotary Northwest Bangalore District 3190 (2013)
- Engineering Watch “Campus Preparedness” Award (2015)
- Cisco NDTV “Digital Pioneer” Award (2016)
- Distinguished Alumnus Award, College of Engineering Guindy (2021)
- IT Visionary Award, StrategINK (2023)